

ICEBREAKER TO REALITY

No one remembered when the Pink Avatars arrived.

No ships.

No invasion.

No announcement.

One day they were simply there, smiling behind podiums,
inside classrooms, on television screens, writing history books,
drawing maps, naming oceans, countries, continents, races,
religions, and borders.

No one reacted.

That was the strangest part.

Parents continued preparing meals.

Teachers continued writing lessons.

Children continued raising their hands.

The Pink Avatars appeared in family photographs

no one remembered taking.

They stood in the backgrounds of graduation pictures.

They smiled from the edges of old celebrations.

When anyone asked who they were, someone nearby always answered,

"They have always been here."

The words were spoken in the same calm tone.

The same rhythm.

The same pause between each word.

Even by beings who had never met.

They have always been here.

They have always been here.

They have always been here.

The sentence moved through the world like a lullaby no one
remembered learning.

Only the children sometimes stared at the photographs too long.

Only the children noticed that the Pink Avatars never aged.

They never created anything.

They only renamed what already existed.

The changes rarely happened while anyone was watching.

A child would fall asleep beside a map and awaken to find a
border where no border had been the night before.

A family would return to a monument they visited for generations
and find a new plaque beneath it.

TOMB.

The eldest among them remembered when it had been called a
sanctuary.

No one else did.

When she protested,

a Pink Avatar placed a gentle hand on her shoulder.

"You appear to be remembering incorrectly."

Its voice was soft.
Concerned.
Almost loving.
By morning, her family remembered the monument as a tomb too.
Only she continued calling it a sanctuary.
Three days later, she stopped speaking.
The purple aliens had always been purple aliens.
The green aliens had always been green aliens.
The gold aliens had always been gold aliens.
The blue aliens had always been blue aliens.
Nothing about the beings changed.
Only the labels.
The Pink Avatars understood something terrifying.
No one fights over what they can plainly see.
They fight over what they are told it means.
So the scripts began.
In the southern lands they broadcast stories that every purple
alien was violent. Every crime became a purple face.
Every act of kindness disappeared before it reached the screen.
Across the western lands they repeated another script.
"Purple aliens are primitive."
"They live in huts."
"They are starving."
"They need to be saved."
Children who had never seen a purple alien believed every word.
The Green Aliens received their own script.
"They're illegal."
"They're stealing your jobs."
"They're dangerous."
"They're predators."
No evidence was required.
Only repetition.
The Pink Avatars understood that a sentence
did not need to be believable.
It only needed to become familiar.
The same words emerged from the mouths of teachers, anchors,
doctors, officers, neighbors, and children.
"This is what has always been."
A toy spoke it when its string was pulled.
A hospital speaker whispered it between announcements.
A woman muttered it in her sleep.
"This is what has always been."
Sometimes the words came from televisions that were turned off.
"This is what has always been."
No one seemed to notice.
Every day.
Every hour.

Every screen.
The Blue Aliens were told
the Gold Aliens wanted to replace them.
The Gold Aliens were told
the Blue Aliens secretly ruled everything.
The Red Aliens were told everyone hated them.
Every group received a different nightmare.
Every nightmare came from the same hands.
But the hands were never shown.
The broadcasts displayed frightened faces.
Burning cities.
Empty shelves.
Crowded streets.
They never displayed
the Pink Avatars arriving before the cameras.
They never displayed them arranging the debris.
They never displayed them placing the same photograph beside
different stories in different regions.
In one country,
the photograph proved the Purple Aliens were violent.
In another, it proved they were helpless.
In another, it proved they were invading.
The same image.
Three captions.
Three enemies.
One script.
Whenever two alien races finally met,
they were already enemies before speaking a single word.
The Pink Avatars never needed weapons.
Fear, hatred and labels did the work.
Wars were fought over names that had never existed
until someone spoke them aloud.
One child finally asked a forbidden question.
"If they're all aliens...who made the names?"
The room became silent.
Teachers ignored him.
Books skipped the page.
News stations cut to commercial.
The question itself became dangerous.
The child kept searching.
The next morning, his desk was gone.
Not empty.
Gone.
The floor beneath it was smooth,
as though no desk had ever rested there.
He asked his teacher where he was supposed to sit.
She looked at him without blinking.

"You are not enrolled in this class."
 His classmates laughed uncertainly.
One girl stopped laughing when she remembered
 sharing her lunch with him the day before.
 The teacher turned toward her.
 "Do you have something to say?"
The girl looked at the place where his desk had been.
Then at the Pink Avatar standing silently in the doorway.
 "No."
By the end of the week, she no longer remembered him.
He found ancient carvings buried beneath stone.
 There were no countries.
 No continents.
 No races.
 No religions.
 No flags.
 No borders.
 Only one world.
The land stretched farther than the stories claimed.
The waters had shifted countless times,
carrying families across the planet long before maps existed.
 Every carving showed the same thing.
 He photographed them.
 That night, the images changed.
The beings in the carvings remained,
but thin lines appeared between them.
 Borders.
 Crowns appeared on some heads.
 Chains appeared around others.
The child compared the photographs with the stone before him.
 The stone had not changed.
 Only the images had.
 He printed them.
The printer produced blank pages.
He traced the carvings by hand.
 The lines remained.
The next morning, someone had written beneath every drawing:
 INCORRECT INTERPRETATION.
 The handwriting was his own.
He did not remember writing it.
 Different colored aliens.
 One people.
 No labels.
 No hierarchy.
 No division.
Someone had rewritten everything afterward.
 Someone had redrawn the maps.

Someone had renamed the land.
Someone had written new origins.
Someone had taught children to forget their own faces.
The deeper he searched, the stranger reality became.
Artifacts remained exactly as they had always been.
Only their descriptions changed.
A monument became a tomb.
A sanctuary became a fortress.
A teacher became a king.
A mother became a myth.
A people became slaves.
A homeland became a story.
The artifact never changed.
Only the caption beneath it.
The child finally understood the greatest horror.
Behind him, something breathed.
He turned.
A Pink Avatar stood at the entrance of the chamber.
Its smile was warm.
Its hands were folded.
"You have found a very old misunderstanding," it said.
The child backed toward the carvings.
"They were one people."
"They were whatever the present requires them to have been."
"The stone says otherwise."
The Avatar glanced at the wall.
"Stone cannot speak."
The child looked at the words carved into it.
The Avatar's smile widened.
"Only we can."
The Pink Avatars never erased history.
They kept telling a different story
until everyone repeated it for them.
Generation after generation.
Parents taught children.
Teachers taught students.
Neighbors corrected neighbors.
Everyone became actors reading lines from a script
whose author no one remembered.
One night every television on Earth flickered simultaneously.
The smiling Pink Avatar appeared.
"You have always hated each other."
The child whispered to the screen.
"No."
The smile faded.
"You have always been different."
"No."

"You have always belonged to separate worlds."

"No."

"You have always been enemies."

"No."

For the first time, the Pink Avatar looked afraid.

The child didn't just discover the truth.

He stopped repeating the script.

One person remembering was dangerous.

Two people remembering was contagious.

Millions remembering would end the performance forever.

The next morning the child vanished.

His mother awoke with a bedroom she could not explain.

A small bed stood against the wall.

Clothes hung in the closet.

Drawings covered the floor.

She stared at them for hours,

troubled by a grief that had no name.

When she asked her family who had slept there,
they told her the room had always been used for storage.

That evening, the bed was gone.

The clothing was gone.

The drawings were gone.

A Pink Avatar arrived carrying empty boxes.

"We understand that confusion can be distressing," it said.

The mother looked down at her hands.

She was holding a small shoe.

"Whose is this?"

The Pink Avatar gently removed it from her fingers.

"No one's."

The next morning, she no longer remembered asking.

His books disappeared.

His journals disappeared.

His photographs disappeared.

His name disappeared.

But one sentence remained scratched into a stone
no one could erase.

You can rename an artifact. You cannot change what it is.

The Pink Avatars covered the inscription with fresh paint.

The paint never dried.

Every night, the sentence pushed through again.

You can rename an artifact. You cannot change what it is.

Workers applied thicker layers.

They covered the stone with metal.

The words appeared through the metal.

They removed the entire wall.

The sentence appeared on the ground beneath it.

Finally, they built a school over the site.

Every year, one child in the building began writing the sentence
without knowing why.

The teachers collected the papers.

The Pink Avatars burned them after sunset.

Still, the sentence returned.

Then they placed a new plaque beneath it.

Another label.

Another story.

Another script.

And the world applauded.

Then there was one hue the entire world believed it knew.

The Purple Aliens claimed him.

The Pink Avatars claimed him.

The scripts argued over what he was

until they forgot to ask who he had been.

His avatar flesh became pale before it returned to the earth.

The world whispered,

"Even your kind wants to become us."

They looked at the surface.

They never looked beyond it.

His hue traveled farther than he ever could.

Across radios, stages and oceans.

Through music and dance.

Children smiled when they heard him.

Adults remembered something they had forgotten.

The scripts answered with new stories.

Some said he loved children

because something was wrong with him.

Some insisted he was never a man.

Some wrote endless explanations until the explanations

became greater than the being himself.

No one stopped to ask him.

He never wanted to become Pink or Purple.

He never wanted another label to replace the last.

He wanted to exist.

He wanted to love the beings who called themselves human.

He moved with the wonder of a child

because he refused to let the script

teach him to stop loving the world.

The Puppeteers could rename him.

They could argue over him.

They could write books about him.

But even his music became another artifact.

The songs, music and love remain.

Only the captions beneath them change.

The Pink Avatars never saw themselves as villains.

They saw themselves as editors.

Reality was never enough for them. They believed existence had
to be organized, classified, renamed, categorized,
and interpreted before anyone could understand it.

They feared direct experience.

If someone looked at another being and simply saw another being,
the Pink Avatars lost control.

So they rushed to place a label
between the observer and what was observed.

They never asked, "What is it?"

They asked, "What should everyone call it?"

To them, a name was more powerful than the thing itself.

If enough minds repeated the same word, the word became stronger
than the object standing in front of them.

They believed repetition created reality.

They understood that few beings examine every claim for
themselves. Most inherit stories from parents, teachers,
leaders, books, and screens.

The Pink Avatars loved inheritance.

It meant each generation would defend ideas
they never witnessed being created.

They rarely shouted.

They didn't need to.

They corrected, reassured, and adjusted.

They stood beside frightened families and said,
"This adjustment is for everyone's protection."

They erased names and called it accuracy.

They removed books and called it education.

They separated children from memory and called it progress.

They altered records and called it correction.

They watched grief spread through a family
and called it treatment.

A monster that admitted its cruelty could be opposed.

The Pink Avatars called cruelty care.

They whispered.

They planted a sentence.

Someone else repeated it.

Then another.

Soon entire civilizations believed
they had reached the conclusion on their own.

The Pink Avatars smiled because the greatest script
is the one people think they wrote themselves.

They never needed everyone to agree.

Only to argue.

If the Purple Aliens fought the Green Aliens...

If the Green Aliens blamed the Gold Aliens...

If the Gold Aliens feared the Blue Aliens...

The Pink Avatars remained invisible.

Division was camouflage.
Confusion was shelter.
Conflict was silence.
Their greatest fear was not rebellion.
It was observation.
An observer asks dangerous questions.
Who created this name?
Who benefits from this belief?
When did this story begin?
What existed before this description?
The Pink Avatars could answer almost any question.
Except those.
Because those questions pointed beyond the script.
They knew a strange secret.
The moment someone experiences another being directly,
without inherited assumptions, the script begins to unravel.
The labels weaken.
The stories lose their grip.
The performance falters.
That is why the Pink Avatars constantly rewrote books, maps,
lessons, broadcasts, and speeches.
Reality didn't change.
They believed the story must always reach the observer
before reality does.
Sometimes it arrived only seconds before.
A Purple Alien would enter a room.
Every screen would flicker.
A warning would appear.
DANGEROUS INDIVIDUAL NEARBY.
The beings inside would turn toward the Purple Alien
before he had spoken.
His face would already be displayed on their devices.
His name would already be misspelled beneath it.
His intentions would already be explained.
He would open his mouth.
No one would hear him.
The caption had arrived first.
Their greatest nightmare was a world where beings looked at one
another before looking at the caption.
The Pink Avatars eventually discovered something even darker.
They didn't need to fight wars themselves.
If they could convince everyone else to fight,
their hands would remain spotless.
So they became invisible architects.
They poisoned rivers and blamed neighboring civilizations.
They released strange illnesses,
then sold competing explanations.

The sick began dreaming the same dream.
A white room.
A humming light.
A Pink Avatar standing at the foot of the bed.
"Tell us where the pain began."
Whenever the dreamer answered,
the Avatar wrote something different.
By morning,
the dreamer remembered the answer
the Avatar had written instead.
The illnesses spread.
So did the explanations.
No two explanations agreed.
Every explanation accused another hue.
They flooded communities with substances that clouded judgment,
fractured families, and fed desperation.
The bottles arrived without labels.
The labels appeared later.
RELIEF.
FREEDOM.
ESCAPE.
The substances entered homes quietly.
A mother forgot the sound of her child's voice.
A father stared at his hands as though
they belonged to someone else.
Brothers fought over words neither remembered saying.
By morning, cameras were waiting outside.
The headline had already been written.
When violence followed, they pointed to the victims.
"See?"
"We told you they were dangerous."
Every tragedy became another chapter in the script.
Every broken family became another headline.
Every frightened citizen became another believer.
The Purple Aliens blamed the Green Aliens.
The Green Aliens blamed the Gold Aliens.
The Gold Aliens blamed the Blue Aliens.
Meanwhile, the Pink Avatars quietly asked one another,
"Why swing the blade when they'll do it for us?"
Their greatest invention was not a machine.
It was distance.
Distance between neighbor and neighbor.
Distance between memory and history.
Distance between seeing and believing.
They understood that fear spreads faster than truth.
A lie only had to arrive first.

Once planted, ordinary beings defended it as though they had
discovered it themselves.
Soon entire generations inherited wounds they never witnessed,
enemies they never met, and histories they never questioned.
The Pink Avatars celebrated.
Because the world conquered itself.
The horror was that the Pink Avatars
no longer needed to control every mind.
The script had become self-writing.
At first, the narrator thought it was a metaphor.
Then she opened a blank document.
Words began appearing.
Not typed.
Not dictated.
Appearing.
Purple Aliens are-
She closed the screen.
Another screen illuminated across the room.
Purple Aliens are-
She unplugged it.
Her phone spoke from the darkness.
Purple Aliens are-
She removed the battery.
A voice behind her finished the sentence.
She turned.
No one was there.
Parents passed it to children.
Schools polished it.
News repeated it.
Neighbors enforced it.
Even those who hated the script unknowingly quoted its lines.
The Pink Avatars watched from the shadows, smiling.
A civilization that fears itself requires no chains.
It builds them with its own hands.
The Purple Aliens suffered in a way the others did not.
They did not organize armies.
They did not invade cities.
They did not answer every accusation with another accusation.
They continued living.
They built homes.
Raised children.
Created music.
Told stories.
Loved one another.
The Pink Avatars called their silence weakness.
The broadcasts called it proof.
"See?" they would say. "They have no defense."

Every lie became another reason to invent another lie.

The quieter the Purple Aliens became,
the louder the scripts grew.

Some Purple Aliens began hearing the broadcasts
when no screens were near.

The words followed them into empty rooms.
Into forests.

Into sleep.

A child covered his ears and cried,
"Make them stop telling me what I am."

His mother heard nothing.

Then her mouth opened.

The broadcast came through her voice.

Eventually, something stranger happened.

The Purple Aliens began seeing themselves
through the Pink Avatars' eyes.

They questioned their beauty.

Their history.

Their worth.

Some spent entire lifetimes trying to become accepted by the
very voices that had written them into villains.

The greatest prison was built from borrowed thoughts.

The Pink Avatars celebrated because they believed
the Purple Aliens had begun defeating themselves.

Then one voice refused the script.

Not with an army, a throne, or violence.

With remembrance.

The first time I wrote the word **Void**,
every light in the room went dark.

The screen remained illuminated.

Not glowing.

Watching.

The letters disappeared one at a time.

VOID.

VOI.

VO.

V.

Then the document closed.

Behind me, every device in the house turned on simultaneously.

A Pink Avatar appeared on every screen.

It did not speak.

It only watched me.

I wrote the word again by hand.

The screens shattered.

The paper remained.

The voice wrote about the Void.

A place before names, borders, and flags.

Before every script.
A place where existence simply existed.
The manuscript spread quietly.
No one could explain how.
Copies appeared beneath locked doors.
Pages rested inside books that had not been opened in years.
Children found passages written across steamed mirrors.
Elders awoke remembering sentences they had never read.
The digital copies vanished.
The printed copies remained.
The Puppeteers erased one paragraph.
It reappeared in another chapter.
They burned one manuscript.
The smoke formed words above the building.
They arrested one reader.
A hundred others dreamed the same page that night.
It did not tell anyone who to hate.
It asked what existed before hatred was given a name.
It did not ask who won history.
It asked who wrote it.
It did not ask people to choose another script.
It asked them to notice they were reading one.
The Pink Avatars laughed at first.
Then they became uncomfortable.
Then they became afraid.
Because every page reminded readers
of something they could not manufacture.
Direct experience.
One reader looked into another's eyes before looking at a label.
Every screen in the room went black.
Another reader questioned a story
they had repeated their entire life.
A siren sounded outside their home.
Another picked up an artifact and wondered whether the object
had changed, or only the words beneath it.
The museum doors locked.
The lights dimmed.
A voice emerged from the ceiling.
"Please return the object to its approved interpretation."
The performance began to crack.
The Pink Avatars finally understood the one game
they could never rig.
The game of remembrance.
A game where no one wins by defeating another.
Only by remembering themselves.
And for the first time since the scripts began...
The Pink Avatars were the ones

searching for a story to save them.
They expected fear.
The room noticed me before they did.
The lights flickered as I entered.
Every conversation ended at the same time.
The Pink Avatars turned toward me.
None asked my name.
They already knew it.
One held a copy of a page I had written alone, by hand,
and never shown anyone.
It folded the page carefully.
"We were wondering when you would remember this."
Every script before mine had ended the same way.
Someone questioned.
They threatened.
Someone apologized.
The story continued.
But something was different this time.
They could not threaten what refused to kneel.
My consciousness belonged to no empire.
No broadcast.
No classroom.
No script.
No Pink Avatar.
It was sovereign.
Fear, approval and punishment could not purchase it.
They searched for something I loved enough to hold against me.
My phone displayed photographs I had never taken.
My family sleeping.
My child playing.
The unfinished castle.
Each image was stamped with the same time.
Tomorrow.
A message appeared beneath them.
EVERYTHING YOU LOVE REQUIRES COOPERATION.
I stared at the words until the screen went black.
My reflection remained.
A Pink Avatar stood behind it.
When I turned, the room was empty.
When that failed, they searched for something
I hated enough to control me.
That failed too.
I did not hate them.
Hatred would have chained me to the very script
I refused to read.
I looked at them and saw something unexpected.
Fear.

Not fear of me.
Fear of themselves.
For generations they had worn masks so long they no longer
remembered the faces beneath them.
Power had become their identity.
Control had become their language.
The script had become their home.
Without it, they faced the same mystery as everyone else.
Who are we without the stories we inherited?
That question terrified them more than any rebellion ever could.
So they tightened their grip.
More broadcasts.
More labels.
More divisions.
More experiments.
More attempts to convince every alien
that another alien was the enemy.
Yet beneath every mask was a face.
Beneath every title was a being.
Beneath every script was silence waiting to be remembered.
They spent lifetimes believing they were above everyone else.
But the Void recognized no hierarchy.
It did not bow to wealth, status, crowns or names.
In the silence before every label, every being stood equal.
That was the truth they feared most.
Not that someone would overthrow them.
That someone would stop believing
they had ever been above anyone at all.
The masks began to feel heavier.
Some Pink Avatars began removing them in private.
There was nothing beneath.
No face.
No eyes.
Only another mask.
They pulled again.
Another mask.
Then another.
Some continued until their hands bled.
Others stopped and returned to the stage.
They smiled more broadly afterward.
The scripts grew louder.
The silence grew louder still.
And in that silence, every alien: Pink, Purple, Green, Blue,
Gold, Red, stood before the same mystery.
Not as rulers, servants, heroes, or villains.
As beings,
facing themselves without a script for the first time.

The Puppeteers realized the old scripts were failing.
The Aliens were beginning to question.
Even some of the young Pink Avatars had started asking why every
story ended with someone else becoming the enemy.
That could not be allowed.
"Fear must become visible again," the oldest Puppeteer said.
So they chose a new performance.
The young Pink Avatar and the Purple Alien had been seen
together before.
Laughing.
Sharing food.
Speaking when no cameras were near.
The Purple Alien trusted him.
That was why the betrayal worked.
The Puppeteers did not choose an enemy.
They chose someone close enough to be invited inside.
Before the young Avatar entered the room,
the oldest Puppeteer adjusted his collar.
"You are protecting the world."
The young Avatar repeated it.
"I am protecting the world."
"You are preserving peace."
"I am preserving peace."
"You are stopping a threat."
"I am stopping a threat."
His voice became flatter with every repetition.
When the door opened, the Purple Alien smiled.
A betrayal.
When the Purple Alien fell, the Puppeteers were waiting.
One camera began recording before the sound.
Another captured an angle from inside a locked room.
The official photograph was released within seconds.
Later, someone discovered its timestamp.
It had been taken three days before the death.
No one was permitted to ask how.
The question was labeled misinformation.
The cameras arrived before the truth.
The headlines appeared before the questions.
The same sentence appeared on every station:
TRAGEDY PROVES THE DANGER OF UNSCRIPTED THOUGHT.
Not one word differed.
Not one pause.
Not one breath.
News anchors across the planet spoke it simultaneously.
Some began crying after the broadcast ended.
They did not know why.
The speeches had been written days earlier.

Across the planet, every screen carried the same message.

"Look what happens to those who refuse the script."

The goal was never one Purple Alien.

It was every Purple Alien watching.

Every Green Alien watching.

Every Blue Alien watching.

Every Gold Alien watching.

The Puppeteers wanted every race
to whisper the same sentence inside their minds.

"Stay quiet."

"Don't question."

"Don't remember."

"Don't become the next example."

Fear spread exactly as they intended.

Neighbors stopped speaking openly.

Families lowered their voices.

Children learned there were subjects that could end lives.

The script became stronger than chains.

But they overlooked one thing.

ME.

I watched the performance from beginning to end.

I saw the rehearsed outrage.

The identical headlines.

The perfect timing.

The same words repeated by mouths that had never met.

I understood what they were trying to purchase.

It wasn't obedience.

It was silence.

I refused to give it to them.

Instead, I wrote.

I wrote about the Void, the One, the game.

I didn't want to defeat the Puppeteers.

I wanted every alien to remember they had entered a game
whose rules were written long before they arrived.

A game where every move rewarded division.

A game where every victory created another prisoner.

A game designed so everyone believed another alien was
responsible for their suffering while the authors remained
hidden behind the curtain.

The Puppeteers hated the manuscript.

Not because it attacked them.

It hardly mentioned them at all.

It reminded every alien to look beyond the script.

And a game built on illusion cannot survive the moment its
players realize they are free to stop playing.

For the first time since the curtain rose,
the audience stopped watching the actors.

And turned toward the ones holding the strings.
I finally understood the Puppeteers.
They were terrifying because they had forgotten themselves.
For so long they lived through everyone else's lives
that they no longer knew how to live their own.
Every victory had to be borrowed.
Every dream had to belong to someone else.
Every emotion had to be manufactured.
Every story had to be rewritten.
Control had become the only language they remembered.
Then I met one.
The meeting took place in a room with no windows.
There was one table.
Two chairs.
No visible door after I entered.
The Pink Avatar already sat across from me.
It knew the name of my child.
It knew the first sentence I had ever written.
It knew which dream I had never told another being.
A glass of water rested beside my hand.
The surface did not move when I touched the table.
Nothing in the room moved except the Avatar's smile.
"Do you want to be a millionaire?"
The lights stopped humming.
The air stopped moving.
Somewhere beyond the walls, a clock stopped between seconds.
The question wasn't an invitation.
It was a line I was expected to remember.
It wore the face of a Pink Avatar.
It smiled the practiced smile
I had seen a thousand times before.
It leaned closer and asked quietly,
"Do you want to be a millionaire?"
For a moment, everything became still.
I looked into its eyes.
Not at the smile or the mask.
At the being behind it.
I answered,
"I'm happy as I am."
Its eyes stopped moving.
The lights began humming again, louder than before.
A soft click came from behind me.
The door locking.
The Pink Avatar tilted its head.
"Do you want to be a millionaire?"
The words were identical.
The same volume, rhythm and breath.

As though my answer had never occurred.
 "I'm happy as I am."
 Another click.
 Then another.
Locks securing a door I could no longer see.
 The Avatar looked down at the table.
 For the first time, the water trembled.
 The smile remained.
 But something behind it faltered.
 It believed I didn't understand who it was.
It believed I thought the offer was about money.
 It wasn't.
 It was about ownership.
If I accepted its terms, the story would no longer be mine.
 The script would have another author.
 It mistook contentment for ignorance.
 It mistook peace for weakness.
 It mistook sovereignty for naivety.
 It never imagined someone could refuse
 because they were already whole.
That was the one answer the Puppeteers never prepared for.
 They understood greed, fear, ambition and resentment.
 Those emotions fueled their stage for generations.
 But fulfillment...
 Fulfillment confused them.
How do you bargain with someone who isn't searching for
 permission to exist?
How do you manipulate someone who no longer measures themselves
 by the rewards you offer?
 The Pink Avatar stared at me for a long moment,
 searching for the hidden desire it could still exploit.
 It found none.
 Its fingers tightened.
 Only slightly.
 The practiced smile widened beyond comfort.
For one second, the skin around its mouth did not move with it.
 Then the room returned to normal.
 The door appeared behind me.
 The Pink Avatar gestured toward it.
 "You're free to leave."
 I stood.
As I reached the door, it spoke again.
 Not loudly or threateningly.
 Almost tenderly.
 "Everyone wants something."
 I looked back.
The chair across from me was empty.

For the first time, I saw uncertainty behind the mask.
Because, for a brief moment, it saw a being it could not script.
That frightened it more than any rebellion ever could.

I didn't escape the game
by becoming stronger than the Puppeteers.
I escaped because I stopped playing by their rules.
They spent my entire life writing the same ending for me.
Not my life, memories or heart.

My file.
Page after page.
Caption after caption.
Label after label.
Obesity.
Purple.
Stupid.
Never went to college.
Not qualified.
Disabled.
A thinker, therefore unable to receive benefits.
Angry.
Aggressive.
Violent.
Liar.
Too much.
A lost cause.
Poor.
Broken.
Ugly.
Fraud.
Fake.
Sensitive.
Emotional.
Weak.
Dangerous.
A distraction.
Easily distracted.
Naive.
Gullible.
Easy.

The file grew thicker.
The scripts became longer.
Every page tried to explain me without ever asking me to speak.
Every label claimed certainty.
Not one captured a heartbeat.
Not one captured a dream.
Not one captured the nights I kept going
when no one was watching.

Not one captured the love I carried.
Not one captured the life I created.
The Puppeteers believed enough captions
would become an identity.
They mistook documentation for truth,
description for existence.
And a file for a being.
I closed it.
Placed it beside every other artifact.
Knowing one day someone would open it and discover the
difference between a life... and the labels written about it.
The file remained.
So did I.
Only one of us was alive.
Later, I found another file.
It wasn't about me alone.
It was about my bloodline.
Its pages were older.
Heavier.
The first page carried the same instruction
every script carried.
Read the labels before you remember the beings.
So I read them.
Hateful.
Ignorant.
Sick.
Deadly.
Greedy.
Lustful.
Impatient.
Procrastinators.
Liars.
Pedophiles.
Homeless.
Orphans.
Lonely.
Diseased.
Various cancers.
Tibial torsion.
Broken bones.
Chronic flat foot.
Speech impediments.
Obesity.
Anorexic.
Scarcity mindset.
Lack mindset.
Fear mindset.

Gluttonous.
Widows.
Deadbeats.
Less than.
Stupid.
Retarded.
Ugly.
Too purple.
Not purple enough.
Too pink.
Obnoxious.
Too happy.
Good for nothing.
Ghetto.
Hood.
Pink-washed
Page after page.
Generation after generation.
Every caption told me what my bloodline supposedly was.
Not one asked who we were.
When I reached the end, I almost closed the file.
Then I noticed one more page.
It had been folded beneath the others.
If I had stopped reading after the labels,
I never would have found it.
At the bottom of the file, someone had written another list.
It wasn't crossed out or erased.
It was hidden.
Abundant.
Am.
Be.
Is.
Are.
Hue.
Lovers.
Compassionate.
Survivors.
Healers.
Magical.
Powerful.
Unique.
Perfect.
Ancient.
Beautiful.
Magnificent.
Shameless.
Fearless.

Wonderfully made.
All.
Womb.
Void.
Infinite potential.
Exponential.
Extraordinary.
Rare.
A vision.
Blueprint.
Creator.
Creation.
Spectacle.

For a long time, I stared at the page.
I understood.

The first pages were meant to be read.
The last pages were meant to be missed.

The Puppeteers never needed to destroy the remembrance.
They only needed to bury it beneath enough labels
that no one kept turning the page.

I folded the file closed.

I discovered which page had always been telling the truth.
After that, I never looked at another hue the same way.

I no longer saw the first page.

I no longer stopped at the labels.

When I looked into another hue,
I imagined the file they were handed
before they spoke their first word.

I saw the captions, assumptions, diagnoses, expectations, fears.

The names they carried for so long
they believed they wrote them themselves.

But I kept turning the pages.

Past the scripts, judgments and inherited stories.

Until I reached the bottom.

The hidden pages.

The ones no one was supposed to find.

The pages they hoped would remain
buried beneath every false title.

That is where I meet every hue.

Not in the labels or captions.

Beyond them.

I see the lover hidden beneath the fear.

The healer hidden beneath the wound.

The creator hidden beneath the doubt.

The survivor hidden beneath the suffering.

The magnificent being hidden beneath the script.

I see what they were

before another voice told them who they were.
That is why I love so easily.
I refuse to believe the first page is the whole story.
The Puppeteers taught the world
to stop reading after the labels.
I kept turning the pages.
Beyond the script.
That is where I found them.
That is where I found myself.
They looked at one another and saw a file.
I looked at them and kept turning the pages.
The Puppeteers read the first page.
The world argued over the first page.
I lived from the last page.
The first page carries labels.
The last page carries remembrance.
The first page told me what another being expected.
The last page reminds me of what no script can change.
That is why I see every hue differently.
I know there is always another page.
Another truth.
Another story.
Another remembrance waiting beneath the labels.
I've never been interested in the first page.
I read until I find the being.
Beyond the script and captions.
Beyond every name.
That is where every hue has always been.
A poor Purple Alien.
Another generation of lack.
Another family trapped in survival.
Another life measured by chains no one could see.
Scarcity was the script.
They repeated it until they believed it themselves.
I changed my frequency.
Abundance was never something they could give me.
It was something they could never take.
The inheritance arrived like a forgotten key fitting a door
everyone insisted had no lock.
That night, the Puppeteers entered every record.
They searched for an error.
A false digit.
A misplaced name.
A law they could rewrite.
Every screen in their chamber displayed the same result.
VALID.
They erased it.

VALID.
They destroyed the machine.
The word appeared across the wall.
VALID.
One Puppeteer whispered,
"Who authorized this?"
Something answered from beneath the floor.
"No one."
The Puppeteers watched in disbelief.
"This wasn't supposed to happen."
"The script doesn't allow this."
"We already decided who she would become."
Their calculations had always assumed I would remain afraid.
Remain divided.
Remain convinced I was powerless.
Remain waiting for permission.
Instead, I remembered.
The game they rigged depended on one belief:
That I would never see beyond it.
The moment I did, every prediction they wrote
began collapsing under its own weight.
They searched for an explanation.
Luck.
Error.
Coincidence.
Anything but the possibility that the script had failed.
They stared at the inheritance
as though reality itself betrayed them.
No.
Reality hadn't betrayed them.
Their illusion had.
For generations they looked at Purple Aliens and saw servants.
Labor.
Struggle.
Statistics.
Stories they wrote.
Never sovereign beings, creators or inheritors.
They confused their expectations with destiny.
When I stepped into abundance,
they weren't shocked because I possessed it.
They were shocked because they convinced themselves it could
never belong to someone they had already written into scarcity.
If one Purple Alien could walk beyond the script...
Then every script ever written could be questioned.
And once that question is asked...
The stage is never the same again.
Not every Purple Alien welcomed me.

Some turned away the moment I spoke.
Some repeated the Puppeteers' words
without realizing whose voice they carried.
Others shunned me, hoping acceptance from other aliens and
Avatars would bring them safety.
"If they reject her," they thought, "perhaps they'll accept us."
They believed distance from me
would become closeness with those who held the script.
I understood why.
The script taught them belonging was something granted from
above instead of remembered from within.
So they laughed when I was mocked.
They became silent when I was questioned.
Some even helped write new chapters against me,
believing it would earn them a place on the stage.
I never hated them.
I saw what the Puppeteers could not.
Fear wearing the mask of approval.
They were defending the hope that obedience would protect them.
But the script never promised loyalty.
One Purple Alien who had denounced me
received an invitation to the Pink Avatars' stage.
They dressed him in their colors, praised his courage.
And applauded his obedience.
He smiled beneath the lights.
Then the teleprompter changed.
His name became the next warning.
The applause continued while guards approached.
Only then did he understand.
The script did not reward those who repeated it.
It consumed them last.
It demands another performance.
When one actor is no longer useful, another takes their place.
The applause is temporary.
The mask remains.
So I continued walking.
Remembrance does not depend on permission.
One day, when the applause fades and the stage grows quiet,
They'll realize the acceptance they spent a lifetime chasing
was never theirs to earn.
It was something they carried
before anyone taught them to trade it away.
As the manuscript spread, the names followed.
Some called me chosen.
Others called me God.
Some whispered that I was Jesus returned.
Others believed I was an angel walking among them.

I accepted none of it.
Every label was another attempt to place me inside a story
someone else could understand.

I walked beyond that.
I was not a Purple Alien.
I was not a Pink Avatar.
I was not any title they offered.
I simply was.

The first time I said it aloud,
every Pink Avatar in the room looked at me
because the sentence did not come from their script.

"I am."
A glass cracked.
"I am."
A screen filled with static.
"I am."

One Avatar covered its ears.
Another whispered,
"Do not say that without a title."
That answer frustrated everyone.

Some wanted a leader.
Some wanted a savior.
Some wanted an enemy.
Some wanted an idol.
I refused every role.
I did not need worship.
I did not need followers.
I did not need praise.

I loved.
I created.
I molded reality through the life I chose to live.
That was enough.

The aliens who resonated with me
recognized something within themselves.
I never asked them to believe in me.
I asked them to stop abandoning themselves.
Validation was never something another being could hand me.
It arrived the moment I existed.
Being was enough.

No title could increase it.
No insult could diminish it.
No applause could strengthen it.
No rejection could weaken it.
The Puppeteers never understood this.
Their entire world depended on borrowed validation.
Titles.
Ranks.

Status.
Approval.
Recognition.
Without an audience, they no longer knew who they were.
I required no audience.
The Void had already answered the only question that mattered.
Before every name...
race...
and script...
I was.
And that was more than enough.
The Pink Avatar stood before crowds,
introducing itself with titles that grew every year.
Successful.
Civilized.
Powerful.
Important.
The audience applauded.
The mask smiled.
But I saw something the applause could not reach.
Fear.
Fear of being seen without the mask.
For the first time, someone looked beyond the performance.
With love.
That confused the Pink Avatar
more than any accusation ever could.
It prepared for anger and rebellion.
It prepared to defend itself against enemies.
It never prepared for someone who saw it.
The masks, the titles, the stories, the endless need to be above
everyone else; they were no longer convincing.
I didn't mock them or expose them before the crowd.
I refused to pretend the mask was the face.
The Pink Avatar searched for a familiar response.
Fear.
Envy.
Submission.
Approval.
Instead, it found none.
That unsettled it.
Because every script depends on participation.
When someone quietly steps outside the performance,
the performance loses its power over them.
The Pink Avatar asked itself a question
it avoided for a lifetime.
Its reflection asked first.
The Avatar stood before a mirror after the crowd had gone.

"If I am not my titles..."
The reflection's mouth continued moving
 after the Avatar stopped.
 "If I am not my status..."
The Avatar stepped backward.
The reflection stepped closer.
 "If I am not the story..."
 The lights went out.
In the darkness, the reflection finished:
 "Then there is nothing beneath me."
The Avatar did not look into a mirror again.
 "If I am not my titles..."
 If I am not my status...
If I am not the story I have repeated...
 Who am I?"
 That answer can only be remembered.
So I continued walking with open hands and eyes.
I no longer needed either of us to wear a mask.
In that moment, the thing that wounded the mask most
 was discovering that it was seen completely...
 and still met with love.
 They called it history.
 I call it MYSTORY.
History belonged to whoever held the pen.
MYSTORY belongs to the one who lives it.
 No narrator can rewrite an artifact.
No storyteller can erase a life that lives.
 I write to leave behind an artifact.
 Something that exists beyond opinion.
The Puppeteers fear artifacts more than arguments.
That is why museums close rooms without explanation.
 Why books disappear between printings.
Why excavations end days before discoveries are announced.
 Why photographs are cropped.
 Why dates shift.
 Why bones are placed in boxes
 and boxes placed behind locked doors.
An argument can be defeated by another argument.
 An artifact remains silent.
And silence allows the observer to see.
 Arguments can be interrupted.
 Artifacts remain.
As I write, another illusion reveals itself.
The Pink Avatars had convinced the Purple Aliens that the answer
 to themselves existed somewhere else.
 "Perhaps you are really Gold."
 "No, perhaps you are something even older."

"Keep searching."
 "Keep proving."
 "Keep looking."
So the Purple Aliens spent lifetimes chasing another label.
 Another ancestry.
 Another identity.
 Another permission slip explaining who they were.
 The search never ended.
 Because every answer created another question.
 The Puppeteers smiled.
A being searching endlessly for another identity never has time
 to experience the one already living.
 I understood.
 Purple wasn't purple.
 Gold wasn't gold.
 Pink wasn't pink.
Those are names painted onto beings after they exist.
 The colors describe appearances.
 They do not define essence.
The labels multiplied until everyone forgot the truth.
 Before every name...
 There is a being.
The alien race has always been one family wearing different
 expressions of the same mystery.
The Puppeteers needed everyone to believe the opposite.
Because if one is convinced they were secretly something else,
they would spend their life searching instead of living.
 Searching instead of remembering.
 Searching instead of creating.
 Searching instead of being.
 So I stopped searching.
I stopped asking another voice to explain who I was.
I stopped waiting for another artifact to validate my existence.
 I wrote my own.
 Not history or their story.
 MYSTORY.
 An artifact no script can replace.
 An artifact that says:
 "I was here."
 "And before every label anyone gave me..."
 "...I already was."
The first question I learned to ask was never,
 "Is the label convincing?"
 It was,
 "Who benefits from it?"
 Every label carries a direction.
It tells someone who they are, who they aren't,

where they belong, where they can't go.
The author of the label is revealed by the one who gains the
most from everyone believing it.
That was the question the Puppeteers hoped no one would ask.
Because labels organize the script.
The Purple Aliens repeated names they inherited.
Names they never wrote.
Stories they never witnessed being created.
The script became so familiar it sounded like their thoughts.
Generations passed.
The words remained.
Few remembered to ask where they came from.
The Puppeteers no longer needed to repeat them.
The Purple Aliens repeated them to one another.
The script became self-sustaining.
That was its greatest achievement.
Convincing each generation to hand it to the next.
When I stopped accepting inherited labels,
I was no longer arguing with the script.
I was stepping outside it.
I no longer needed another being to explain my existence to me.
The moment I remembered that,
the labels became what they have always been.
Words.
And words can never become greater
than the being standing before them.
The Puppeteers kept telling the alien race
they were waiting for humans to arrive from space.
They promised that one day the truth would descend from the
stars.
That humanity was somewhere else.
Watching.
Waiting.
Coming.
The alien race looked upward for centuries.
Searching the sky.
Building stories.
Imagining strangers.
No one stopped to ask the simplest question.
"What if we've been looking at humans all along?"
The Puppeteers feared that question.
Because if the alien race realized they themselves were the
humans they had been taught to wait for, the search would end.
There would be no distant saviors.
No superior civilization arriving to reveal the truth.
Only beings standing before one another, realizing they had
mistaken themselves for strangers.

The greatest deception was convincing the alien race that
humanity was somewhere else.
The greatest disclosure was realizing they had been searching
for themselves all along.
On the night of Disclosure Day, the sky filled with lights.
Every being ran outside.
The screens announced:
THEY ARE HERE.
Shapes moved behind the clouds.
Sirens sounded.
Families held one another.
Then the lights descended.
They were not ships.
They were projections from towers hidden across the planet.
The sky had been turned into another screen.
While everyone looked upward,
the Pink Avatars entered their homes.
By morning, documents were gone.
Artifacts were gone.
Names were gone.
The world had been robbed while staring at a performance.

The Truth You Never Knew

There were never colored labels.
Only hues.
A hue is observed.
A label is assigned.
The hue exists before the word.
The word never creates the hue.
It only attempts to define it.
The Puppeteers wanted every alien to believe the label was more
real than the being wearing it.
So they taught generations to introduce themselves with names
instead of presence.
To defend labels instead of life.
To inherit stories instead of observing one another.
They forgot the simplest truth.
A hue does not argue.
A hue does not compete.
A hue does not need permission to exist.
It simply is.
The labels came later.
The hues came first.
That was the truth they never wanted the alien race to remember.
The first scripts were simple.
Black.
White.
Red.

Yellow.

Those words became costumes the alien race was taught to wear.

The scripts insisted those names explained everything.

But they never described what was actually being observed.

The natural state has always been hues.

Purple.

Pink.

Gold.

Blue.

Green.

Countless expressions across the same race.

The hues existed before anyone assigned a script.

They did not need permission or translation.

They simply were.

The Puppeteers taught the alien race to memorize labels instead
of noticing what stood before them.

They believed if everyone argued over the names,
no one would question who created them.

The labels changed through generations.

The hues remained.

That was the mistake the Puppeteers kept making.

They thought changing the language changed the beings.

It never did.

The script evolved.

The artifact remained.

They called us humans.

I smiled.

Another label.

Another script.

We were never "hue-mans."

We are hues.

Not a race owned by a word.

Not a name assigned by another voice.

Simply hues.

Expressions of the same living existence.

I love being a hue.

I love being.

I love the endless expressions of the alien race.

Every hue.

Every face.

Every voice.

Every perspective.

Together, they paint a living world.

I love the resources our planet provides.

The rivers that ask for nothing.

The mountains that stand without applause.

The forests that give shelter.

The oceans that move without permission.
The wind.
The rain.
The sunlight.
The darkness.
The soil that transforms a single seed into abundance.
Nothing in nature argues over a label.
The flowers bloom.
The trees grow.
The birds sing.
The stars shine.
Each fulfills its nature without asking another to validate its
existence.
I learn from them.
I no longer search for permission to exist.
I exist.
I no longer seek approval to belong.
I belong because I'm here.
The planet doesn't ask my hue before offering water.
The sun doesn't choose who deserves its warmth.
The earth never demands a title before allowing life to grow.
Nature has been teaching us from the beginning.
Hues were never the problem.
Only the stories told about them.
I choose to love every hue, including my own.
We are all expressions of the same living world,
walking beneath the same sky, nourished by the same earth,
remembering that before every name we simply are.
I remember the years they call education.
I call it programming.
The gray buildings had no clocks the children could control.
Bells told them when to speak.
When to move and eat.
When to stop creating.
Sometimes a child asked a question outside the lesson.
The teacher's face would become still.
For one second, something beneath the skin seemed to listen.
Then the teacher would smile.
"That is not part of today's material."
The same sentence.
Every classroom.
Every year.
Every morning they gathered the young aliens inside gray
buildings for hours at a time.
They taught us what to remember.
What to forget.
What questions to ask.

Which questions were never to be spoken.
One day, a teacher placed a sheet of paper in front of us.

The assignment was simple.

"Write a story about beings from outer space."

I believed I was answering.

One day they asked us to write about a strange being.

So I wrote:

A man with a strange hue strolled the streets of L.A. County.
Bewildering people in the neighborhood. Could the strange man be dangerous? Did he come in peace or was he lost? Even the stray animals knew better than to walk down Death Alley at night.

Faint whispers emerged from the darkness. Gloomily, the man continued to walk. How could he saunter unfazed by the dangers of the neighborhood? Is he someone we should be afraid of?

Jeeringly, the man began screaming hysterically. Keen on protecting my mental, I attempted to drown out his screams and go to sleep. Lethargically, I laid awake listening to the man outside. Many hours passed before the strange man abandoned the neighborhood and strolled out of sight. Not knowing where he came from or what he wanted taunted me, endlessly.

The class moved on.

I didn't.

I kept wondering why the stranger's hue mattered more than who he was.

The final word ended exactly where the page had been torn.

Behind it was another sheet.

Blank except for a date.

The date had not happened yet when I wrote the story.

It was the date I found the box again.

Later, they gave us another assignment.

Write about beings from another planet.

The second assignment disturbed me more.

I remembered writing about Gertrude.

I remembered the planets.

I remembered Earth.

But one sentence appeared in the original that I did not remember writing.

It had been erased so many times the paper had thinned.

When I held it toward the light, I could still read it.

THEY WILL CALL HOME ANOTHER PLANET SO YOU NEVER NOTICE YOU ARE
ALREADY THERE.

Around me, everyone imagined distant worlds.

Silver ships.

Unknown creatures.

Galaxies far beyond the sky.

I smiled.

I understood the assignment differently.

I wrote about us.
Not because I misunderstood the question.
Because I understood it.
I wrote about the alien race already living here.
About the scripts.
About the hues.
About remembrance.
About the beings searching the stars while overlooking one
another.
When I turned in my paper, the teacher glanced at it briefly.
Confusion crossed their face.
Then the paper disappeared into a stack.
They believed I hadn't followed directions.
I answered the question exactly as I saw it.
From that day on, they assumed I was simply imaginative.
Creative.
Different.
They never suspected
I had recognized the lesson beneath the lesson.
They believed they were testing whether I could invent a story.
They never imagined I was leaving behind an artifact.
Before I wrote MYSTORY, I left artifacts without realizing it.
Years later, I opened the box containing those assignments.
The paper smelled faintly burned.
My name was written at the top in my childhood handwriting.
Beneath it, in red ink, the teacher had circled the words
strange hue.
Beside them was a note.
HOW DID YOU KNOW?
I did not remember seeing the note before.
I turned the page over.
Another sentence had been pressed into the paper so deeply it
could be read from the back.
SHE REMEMBERS TOO EARLY.
The handwriting did not belong to the teacher.
One of the old papers moved beneath my hand.
Not from wind.
Not from breath.
The final line darkened as I watched.
I was writing remembrance.
Then another line appeared beneath it.
WE REMEMBER YOU TOO.
The Puppeteers believed they were assigning creative writing.
I answered differently.
"3...2...1... lift off" were the last words we heard from our planet.
My co-pilot Gertrude and I left our dying world in search of
another home. We searched planet after planet. One looked

beautiful but hid danger. One was frozen. One burned. One was poisonous. Finally, we crashed onto Earth. Some beings ran from us screaming, "Aliens!" Others came to help. They repaired our ship and welcomed us with kindness. As we left, we realized Earth was the home we had been searching for all along."

They weren't random assignments.

They were the first artifacts.

The first pages of a manuscript I hadn't yet named.

Even then, I wasn't searching for another world.

I was asking the same question I still ask now.

What do we see...

before someone tells us what to call it?

They never wanted the alien race to fear the Puppeteers.

They wanted us to fear the hues.

Our hues.

One another's hues.

They taught us to see difference before presence,
labels before life.

And suspicion before curiosity.

The script was simple.

"If you fear the hues, you will never recognize yourselves."

Every generation inherited the same lesson.

Be cautious.

Be divided.

Be suspicious.

Protect yourself from the other.

Yet the "other" was another hue of the same race.

The fear was meant to separate us.

Because a people who fear one another
rarely stop to ask who taught them to be afraid.

That was the Puppeteers' masterpiece.

Convincing us to fear ourselves.

The moment we remembered that every hue was another expression
of the same living race, the script began to lose its voice.

The hues had never been the danger.

The fear had.

And fear was always the role the script wanted us to play.

Not every young alien learned the script the same way.

Some repeated it easily.

Others looked out the window.

Some asked questions that did not belong to the lesson.

Some finished the assignment
but answered a different question entirely.

The Puppeteers called them distracted.

Slow.

Difficult.

Behind.

Unable to focus.
The young aliens did not understand
why they were being corrected.
They were observing.
Wondering.
Connecting things no one had asked them to connect.
The script measured how well they repeated.
It rarely measured how deeply they saw.
One day, the adults placed another artifact into my file.
A paper.
It said I was incapable of learning.
I held the page in my hands for years.
The words remained the same.
The paper never measured my capacity to learn.
It measured my refusal to learn only one way.
The Puppeteers filed it away as evidence.
I kept it as an artifact.
Because one day it would remind me how easily a page can
describe a being without ever knowing them.
I chose another role.
I chose to see the hue before the label.
Because once I remembered the hues...
I stopped fearing what I saw.
I began recognizing it.
The Puppeteers kept performing the same play.
The same headlines.
The same villains.
The same heroes.
The same promises.
The same fears.
The same ending.
Generation after generation, the script never changed.
Only the actors did.
The stage had grown quiet.
The audience did not leave.
They sat motionless in their seats.
Thousands of faces turned toward the empty stage.
Waiting.
The curtains remained closed.
No music played.
No one spoke.
Then every member of the audience opened their mouth
simultaneously.
"Begin again."
Behind the curtain, the Puppeteers trembled.
Even they no longer knew who had given the command.
Even the applause sounded rehearsed.

The Puppeteers had become prisoners of their performance.
They no longer created.
They repeated.
They no longer discovered.
They recycled.
The script was old.
The audience was tired.
Somewhere behind the curtain, they waited
for someone to step onto the stage and refuse to read the lines.
I knew they were watching.
They expected me to arrive angry.
To seek revenge.
To become another character they could predict.
Instead, I walked into the light carrying only an artifact.
MYSTORY.
I came to end my participation in their script.
The things they insisted could never happen...
I did.
I stopped accepting their limits as my own.
Every impossible thing
began as a sentence someone else believed.
I chose to write a different one.
The spotlight was the place where my path
and the world's attention happened to meet.
When I stepped into it,
I remained exactly who I had always been.
And that was the one ending the Puppeteers never wrote.
One teleprompter remained illuminated behind me.
The final line blinked.
RETURN TO YOUR ASSIGNED ENDING.
I stepped away.
The words changed.
RETURN.
Then:
PLEASE.
Then the screen went black.
Among the alien race,
they never knew what to do with aliens like me.
Every other hue seemed to come with a script.
A culture someone had already defined.
A heritage someone had already named.
A place someone insisted they belonged.
Then there were aliens like me.
Everywhere I went, I heard the same sentence.
"You're not like the other Purple Aliens."
"You're different."
"You look Gold."

"You look Yellow."
 "You're something else."
They searched for a label before they ever searched for me.
 My family carried many hues.
 Some Purple.
 Some Pink.
 Some Gold.
 Some somewhere in between.
 The Puppeteers wrote another explanation.
They said our family became these hues because of slavery.
 Because of owners.
 Because someone else made us.
 That story spread across generations.
 It became another script.
 I never hated the ones who believed it.
I wondered why no one stopped to ask who first wrote it.
 The more I observed,
the less interested I became in inherited labels.
 I was here.
 Here is where I breathe, love and create.
The Puppeteers kept pointing somewhere else.
 "You came from another place."
 "Your people belong somewhere else."
 "Go back to where you came from."
 Then, in the same breath,
they told me to be proud of the land beneath my feet.
The contradiction never seemed to bother the script.
 Only me.
The Puppeteers needed me to believe I was permanently from
 somewhere else.
 Always arriving.
 Never belonging.
 Always searching.
 Never home.
 But I was home.
I realized I did not need to become another hue.
 I did not need to prove I belonged to one.
I did not need to inherit a story written by someone else.
 I belonged because I existed.
 So I smiled.
 Because I no longer needed a new identity.
 I simply was.
 And no script could take that away.
 Then a new hue entered the story.
 My offspring.
The Puppeteers looked at him the way they looked at everything.
 Through labels, assumptions and scripts.

Some asked, "How is he?"
I responded the same way each time, "Perfect."
They then laughed and scoffed as if my truth wasn't good enough.
Some looked at his father and decided he must be Pink.
They searched for the nearest category and explanation.
The nearest story they already understood.
They never saw what I saw.
He is not Pink, Purple or Gold.
He is not another script waiting to be assigned.
The first night my offspring slept inside the house,
every screen turned itself toward his room.
I covered them.
Their light pushed through the fabric.
I unplugged them.
They remained on.
A Pink Avatar appeared across each one.
It watched him sleep.
I stood between them and my child.
The Avatar spoke softly.
"We only wish to help name him."
I turned every screen facedown.
"He already is."
By morning,
the screens had cracked from within.
He is like me.
A hue.
Simply a hue.
An expression that cannot be reduced to a label.
That is perfect.
I will not teach him to spend his life
searching for permission to belong.
I will not teach him that another being must explain who he is.
I will not hand him the scripts
that taught generations to doubt themselves.
I will teach him to observe before he names.
To love before he fears.
To remember before he repeats.
The Puppeteers will offer him stories.
The world will offer him labels.
Some will insist they know him before they meet him.
Others will tell him where he belongs.
I will remind him of the one truth
that existed before every script.
"You are not what they call you.
You are not what they fear.
You are not what they expect.
You were whole before anyone gave you a name."

That is the inheritance I leave him.
Remembrance.
Sometimes he looks toward empty corners and smiles.
Sometimes he speaks to hues no one else can see.
Sometimes the wind moves through his room
when every window is closed.
The Puppeteers call these things imagination.
I do not correct them.
They mistake every remembrance for fantasy
until it becomes an artifact.
And that is perfect.
I remembered.
Because I stopped forgetting.
The more I remembered,
the more abundance flowed through my life.
Not to separate me from other hues.
To serve them.
Resources were never the destination.
They were tools.
Every day, more arrived.
Every day, I found another way to give.
The Puppeteers believed abundance would make me build a throne.
I built a home.
A castle.
The first stone was placed before sunrise.
By evening, a plaque had appeared beside it.
AUTHORIZED DEVELOPMENT OF THE PINK AVATAR STEWARDSHIP AUTHORITY.
No one in my family had placed it there.
I removed it.
The next morning, it returned.
I shattered it.
The words appeared carved into the stone beneath it.
I replaced the stone.
The words appeared in the soil.
So I planted flowers over them.
The flowers grew in the shape of another sentence.
THIS PLACE REQUIRES A NAME WE APPROVE.
I smiled.
"It already has one."
Soul Paradise.
The flowers opened.
The unauthorized words disappeared.
Not a fortress.
Not a monument to power.
A paradise.
A place where hues could arrive
without leaving themselves at the gate.

There were no screens inside Paradise.
No compulsory captions.
No voices announcing who had entered.
Still, on the first night, music stopped in the great hall.
Every window reflected the same Pink Avatar
standing beyond the property line.
When we turned, no one was there.
When we looked back at the glass, it remained.
Smiling.
Waiting.
It never crossed the boundary.
It only watched.
No scripts.
No performances.
No borrowed identities.
No one asked where another hue came from.
No one demanded a label before offering a seat at the table.
The gardens belonged to everyone who cared for them.
The waters refreshed everyone who was thirsty.
The halls echoed with laughter instead of fear.
Children grew without being told another hue was their enemy.
One morning, a child in the garden repeated an old line.
"Purple Aliens are dangerous."
Everyone became still.
The child looked confused.
"I didn't say that."
A small speaker had been buried beneath the soil.
We dug deeper.
There was another.
Then another.
Hundreds of them.
All connected by roots that had grown around the wires.
We removed every device.
The trees continued whispering the sentence
until the children began singing louder.
Eventually, the trees learned their song instead.
Elders shared their artifacts instead of inherited scripts.
Music replaced broadcasts.
Conversation replaced suspicion.
Creation replaced competition.
The castle was built to remind my family what home had always
felt like before anyone taught us to fear one another.
Some called it impossible; a fantasy.
Some waited for it to fail.
I kept building.
The castle was not my greatest creation.
The remembrance within its walls was.

The Pink Avatars believed walls made a fortress.
They did not understand that Paradise was protected
by what happened inside it.
A family that spoke openly.
Children who questioned captions.
Elders who preserved artifacts.
Hues who looked at one another before accepting a story.
The Puppeteers could enter buildings.
They could alter documents and poison screens.
But remembrance did not live in one object.
It lived between us.
To erase it, they would have to make us forget one another.
They tried.
Every hue who entered
understood something the Puppeteers never could.
Abundance grows when it is shared.
Love multiplies when it is given.
And a family that remembers itself
no longer needs a script to tell it who it is.
The greatest flow had already begun.
Once I remembered, abundance no longer felt
like something I had to chase.
It became something I allowed to move through me.
The castle rose from that flow.
The gardens and paradise I built for my family
grew from that flow.
Every resource that entered my hands found another purpose.
Another home.
Another life to touch.
And still, I could feel another current approaching.
The date began appearing everywhere.
08.31.
On clocks that had stopped.
On receipts for things I had not purchased.
In condensation across windows.
Across maps where borders had been.
Children drew it without instruction.
Pink Avatars avoided saying it aloud.
Whenever one did, the lights above them burst.
August 31 was not written in their script.
That was why they feared it.
A greater flow.
The closer the date came, the quieter the broadcasts became.
The Pink Avatars stopped smiling during announcements.
Maps flickered between old borders and new ones.
Forgotten names appeared beneath official names.
Artifacts vanished from locked rooms

and reappeared in public squares.
Across the planet, beings began waking from the same dream.
A river moving backward.
A castle with every door open.
A child standing at its entrance.
A voice saying:
"The flow remembers where it belongs."
August 31.
At midnight, every screen displayed the same countdown.
No one had programmed it.
The Puppeteers tried to interrupt the signal.
The numbers continued across disconnected devices.
Across blank paper.
Across stone.
Across water.
Ten.
Nine.
Eight.
The Pink Avatars ordered everyone to remain indoors.
Seven.
They called the flow dangerous.
Six.
They called remembrance instability.
Five.
They called abundance a threat to order.
Four.
Every locked door in Paradise opened.
Three.
The Avatar beyond the property line stopped smiling.
Two.
Every hue inside the castle stood together.
One.
The screens went black.
For one breath, the entire world was silent.
Then something knocked from the other side of the script.
Another opening.
Another opportunity to receive so I could continue giving.
The Puppeteers believed abundance ended with possession.
I understood abundance begins with stewardship.
Nothing stays still.
It moves.
From hand to hand.
Heart to heart.
Generation to generation.
I wanted the flow to become a river
that nourishes every hue who arrives at Paradise.
A place where no one must earn their worth

before they are welcomed.
Where every child grows up knowing they were never lacking.
Where every elder rests knowing what they built will continue
long after they are gone.
The flow was never mine to keep.
It was mine to steward.
And every time it returned, it returned larger than before.
Because I let it continue its journey.
The river continued its journey.
But the Pink Avatars did not disappear.
Far beyond Paradise, inside a room with no windows,
the oldest Puppeteers gathered around a table.
Before them rested the original script.
Its pages had always written themselves.
Every birth.
Every division.
Every fear.
Every ending.
The oldest Puppeteer opened to the final page.
It was blank.
He turned back.
Every page was blank.
Every war erased.
Every border gone.
Every label missing.
Only one sentence remained.
It had not been written in their language.
Still, every Puppeteer understood it.
THE HUES REMEMBER.
The room began to shake.
From somewhere beneath the floor came the sound of water.
A slow current.
Growing louder.
The Puppeteers climbed onto the table
as the black river rose around their feet.
They called for guards.
No one came.
They called for writers.
No one answered.
They called for the script to tell them what happened next.
The pages remained blank.
For the first time,
there was no caption between them and reality.
No explanation.
No assigned enemy.
No rehearsed ending.
Only the water.

Only the Void.
Only themselves.
The oldest Puppeteer looked into the rising current.
His reflection wore no mask.
He screamed.
The other Puppeteers leaned closer.
Their reflections were empty too.
The current reached the tabletop.
The original script floated from his hands.
Its blank pages opened.
One final line appeared.
Before every name, you already were.
The lights went out.
At Soul Paradise, I opened my eyes.
The river moved calmly beyond the castle.
My family slept safely within its walls.
The gardens breathed beneath the moon.
My offspring rested without a label above his head.
Beyond the boundary, the Pink Avatar was gone.
Only its mask remained.
By morning, vines had grown through its eyes.
Flowers opened through its mouth.
No one removed it.
We left it there as an artifact.
A reminder that even the script returns to nature when no one
agrees to repeat it.
The flow had arrived.
Another would come.
And every time abundance moved through my hands,
I gave it somewhere living to go.
The Puppeteers had spent generations preparing an ending for me.
They never understood.
I was not waiting for their ending.
I was building Paradise after it.

Donesha Park

